

How to Format Dialogue in 9 Steps + Examples

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Contents



Before you can [craft great dialogue](#), you need to know how to format it.

Correctly formatted dialogue is essential for conveying your story smoothly and allowing readers to effortlessly follow every conversation.

Before we dive into making your characters' voices truly awesome, let's nail the basic mechanics. This article covers 10 straightforward rules about how to format dialogue plus some helpful tips.

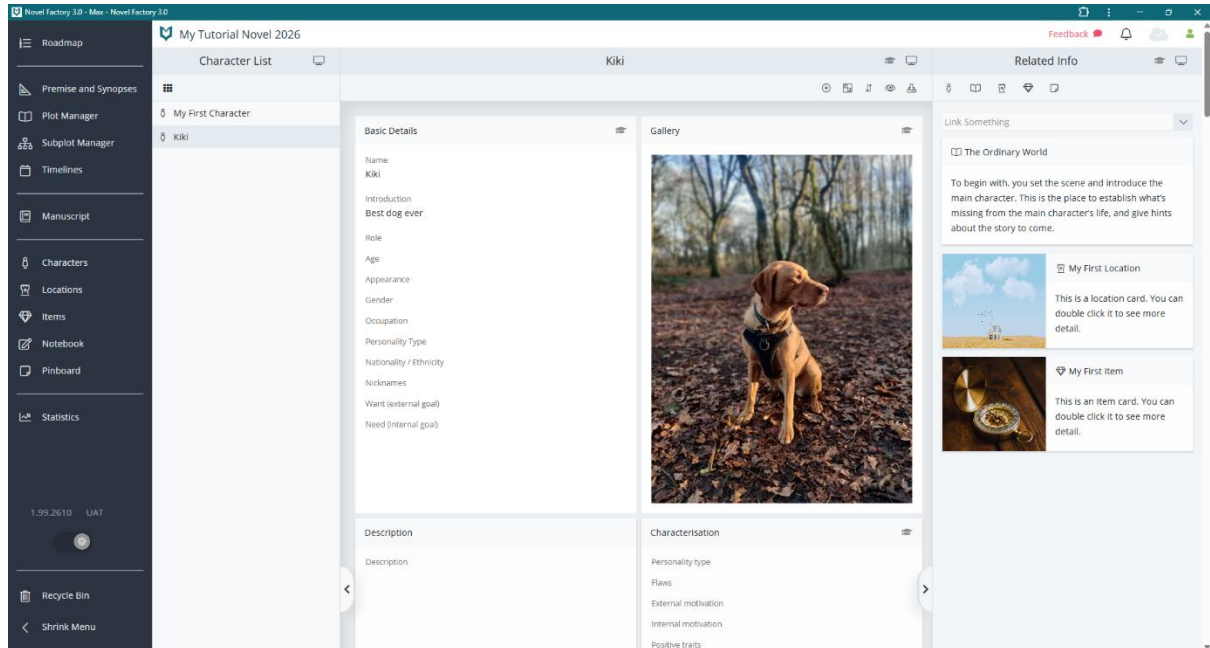
What Is Dialogue Writing?

Dialogue is any conversation between [characters](#) in a narrative.

It's the most direct way to reveal a character's personality and background (voice) and is essential for advancing the plot by conveying information, creating conflict, and building tension.

In prose, spoken words are enclosed in quotation marks, and formatting requires a new paragraph every time the speaker changes. Good dialogue sounds natural and ensures every spoken word serves a narrative purpose.

Before you continue to the article about dialogue writing, we just wanted to let you know that if you're writing a novel, the Novel Factory app contains heaps of useful resources and tools, like craft advice, character questionnaires and plot outlining tools.



The app also contains freeform noteboards, timelines, statistics tracking, and pretty much anything you might want as an aspiring or experienced novelist. It's the tool Katja Kaine designed and used to write her novel, *Blood of Gods and Girls*, which won a major six-figure deal, and will be [published later this year](#).

You can try it completely free for 30 days, and if you don't like it, simply export your work and walk away. But perhaps you could be the next person giving us a quote like this:

"I'm sitting here in awe, I don't even know what to say. It's like you reached into my head and somehow produced a tool that organizes information in the exact way my brain wants to, and it is intuitive and clean. The two biggest things for me are 1) The index cards. Being able to drag and drop scene summaries is quite literally a dream come true. 2) The linking. My god, the linking. All I can say is thank you. "

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How to Format Dialogue in 10 Steps

Writing dialogue is simple when you know what to do. Follow these 10 dialogue writing steps for.

1. Quotation marks

All dialogue should be enclosed in either double quotes (North American style) or single quotes (European style):

- “This is a simple dialogue example.”
- ‘We hope you enjoy our guide.’

2. Dialogue tags

Tags indicate who is speaking and may also show how they speak. Examples include: ‘she said’, ‘he asked’ and ‘they shouted’.

When tags follow dialogue, the tag and the spoken words form part of a complete sentence. A comma is used inside the quotes, followed by a lower-case tag outside the quotes (unless it’s a name or the pronoun I):

- “I’d like a coffee,” she said.
- “I’d like a coffee,” I said.

Tags that come before dialogue also use a comma, but the first word of dialogue is capitalised as it’s the first thing the character is saying:

- He said, “Just a moment.”

Tags that break apart dialogue, known as a beat, form part of a complete sentence with the first words spoken. The next words spoken start a new sentence:

- “Thanks,” she said. “I’m at table three.”

3. Punctuation: questions and exclamations

Question marks and exclamation marks follow the same rules as the comma. They go inside the quotes, and the tag following the dialogue is still part of the same sentence, so stays lowercase:

- “Do you like my hat?” he asked.
- “Love it!” she replied.

4. Action beats

Action beats enhance dialogue by showing your character’s behaviour.

Unlike tags, they don’t describe what’s being spoken, so a period is used inside the quotes. The beat outside the quote starts a new sentence:

- “I’ll be back tomorrow.” She threw open the door.

The same applies to action beats used before or during dialogue:

- He leaned down to pet the cat. “Do you have to leave?”
- “They need me!” She stepped onto the porch. “This is an important meeting.”

5. New paragraph for each speaker

While tags and action beats help readers see who is speaking, if everything were written in a single long paragraph, it would be hard to figure out whether the tag or beat belonged with the dialogue before or after it.

To indicate a new speaker, always use a new paragraph:

- “I’m going to grab some milk on the way home,” he called from the door. “Maybe some snacks too. Need anything?”
- She leaned against the wall. “We haven’t had any party mix for a while. What about the ones with the little crunchy cheese bits?”
- “Too expensive,” he said. “I’ll get you something else.”

6. Multi-paragraph dialogue

When a character is giving a long speech (more than a few sentences), breaking it up into multiple paragraphs helps readers follow along. To carry over the dialogue, don’t close the quote on the first paragraph. Only use a closing quote on the last paragraph (abbreviated example):

- “...and so ends the first paragraph of dialogue.
- “And so ends the second paragraph.”

8. The ellipsis

An ellipsis, or three periods, is used to indicate a character trailing off. Like other punctuation, a tag following the ellipsis is lower-case. You do not need any other punctuation with an ellipsis:

- “I’m not so sure about that...” he said.

10. Indirect dialogue

Sometimes characters talk about an event or describe a story that happened to them. The way they remember what happened might not be accurate, so don’t write everything out in full dialogue, but rather as narrative summary. In this case, regular rules of grammar apply:

- I asked him for some licorice. He told me I couldn't have any, and I told him to stuff it. He hasn't spoken to me since.

Characters might also render (however imperfect) direct retellings of what someone else said. To quote dialogue within dialogue, use the opposite set of quotations from whatever you're using regularly, whether double for North American style or single for European style:

- "I asked her, 'Hey, give me some licorice.'" (Single quotes within double, North American style)
- "'Not a chance,'" she said to me.' (Double quotes within single, European style)

Formatting Dialogue Tips

Dialogue Punctuation

Getting your dialogue punctuation right ensures your reader knows exactly when a character is speaking and keeps the conversation flowing smoothly.

- **Quotation Marks:** Always enclose the speaker's exact words in double quotation marks ("...").
- **Punctuation Placement:** All punctuation marks (periods, commas, question marks, exclamation points) that belong to the dialogue must go inside the closing quotation mark.
 - *Example:* "I'm ready to leave," she said.
- **Commas with Tags:** Use a comma to separate the dialogue from the dialogue tag (e.g., *she said, he asked*).
 - *Example (Tag at end):* "That was a surprise," she whispered.
 - *Example (Tag in middle):* "That was," she whispered, "a real surprise."

How to Indent Dialogue

There are no hard and fast rules for indenting dialogue or starting new paragraphs for dialogue. You can do whatever feels right for your story. Just ensure you stay consistent.

Here are three different options you could consider:

- **New Paragraph Rule:** Start a new paragraph every single time the speaker changes. Even if a character only says one word, it gets its own paragraph. You could indent it or not.
- **Action Paragraphs:** If a character's dialogue is interrupted by an action or description, the action goes in the same paragraph as the dialogue tag, or in its own paragraph if the action is lengthy.

- *Example (Action):* He tapped his foot impatiently. “We don’t have all day.”
- **Continuous Text:** Although a less popular formatting option, you could include your dialogue naturally within your paragraphs without specifically separating it out.

Rules of Dialogue

Beyond the technical formatting, high-quality dialogue must sound realistic and serve a clear narrative purpose. Focus on these three practical techniques to elevate your character conversations.

- **Avoid Overuse of Tags:** Use “said” and “asked” often; they are nearly invisible to the reader. Only use stronger tags (e.g., *exclaimed*, *muttered*, *whispered*) when the manner of speaking is truly important.
- **Show, Don’t Tell:** Instead of relying on adverbs in dialogue tags (e.g., *he said angrily*), use **action beats** to show the emotion.
 - *Better:* He slammed his fist on the table. “I’m not doing it.”
- **One Idea Per Speech:** Keep individual lines of dialogue focused. Avoid lengthy monologues unless they are necessary for dramatic effect or character voice.

Dialogue Rules Conclusion

You’ve now got the essential toolkit for formatting dialogue! By using clear quotation marks, proper commas, and consistent paragraph breaks, you make the conversation easy for your reader to follow.

The goal isn’t just to be correct; it’s to make the mechanics *invisible*.

Now that you’ve mastered this foundation, you can move onto the fun part: focusing entirely on the creative rules—like making your characters sound unique and ensuring every word they say moves your story forward.